

FACTIONS, PRODUCTION & HEROES

The Powers and Peoples of Arda - revision 4

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Choose a faction, develop its distinctive production network, create its one hero, and combine the two to win. Every faction has one fixed hero type and one active hero slot. When that hero dies, the slot becomes vacant until the same hero is recreated with resources and time.

Family	Main strength	Main limitation
Valar	Exceptional hero and domain magic	Small sanctuary, few production sites, small supporting army
Melkor: two doctrines	Worldbreaker: personal might; Dark Architect: cities and monsters	Choose one for the campaign; only Melkor commands Balrogs and Dragons
Sauron	Command, binding, workshops and organized armies	Costly control network and dependence on functioning industry
Generic Istari orders	Specialized spells, enchanted items, constructs and support	Small armies and reliance on preparation
Elven clans	Elite companies, skilled craft and enchantment	Slow, expensive replacement
Three human kingdoms	Cities, logistics and large specialized armies	Heroes are more vulnerable; armies need supply
Dwarves and Orcs	Industry, engineering, equipment or economical mass production	Terrain, food and workshop dependencies
Creatures and guardians	Lairs, habitats and unusual movement or combat	Specialized infrastructure and narrow economic options

Three human kingdoms: Gondor / Citadel Engineer; Rohan / Rider Marshal; Númenor / Ocean Warden. Each has one unique hero.

Five generic Istari orders: Ember, Grove, Veil, Forge and Star. Each has one hero type with generated appearance and personality.

Elves: eight clans or houses, each with distinct production and a unique hero.

Visual direction remains: huge isometric painted landscapes, tiny expressive figures, carefully made objects, intimate portraits and consequential dialogue inspired by Disco Elysium.

Revision 4 adds Melkor's two doctrines and exclusive command of all Balrogs and Dragons. Production, hero return and creature loyalty are deliberate game rules. Earlier reports are archived.

01 / What factions actually produce

Every faction has a basic economy and specialist recipes. Buying an allied product does not automatically teach its recipe.

Stock	Gathered or generated through	Spent on
P - Provisions	Farms, herds, fisheries, hunting or habitat care	Recruiting, creature feeding, army upkeep and some heroes
M - Materials	Forest work, quarrying, mines, salvage and trade	Buildings, weapons, ships, tools and crafted bodies
K - Lore supplies	Scribes, research work, recovered records and study	Training, research, ritual preparation and magical craft
E - Essence	Rare map sites, discoveries and slow sanctuary rituals	Hero manifestation, summons, enchantments and major magic

M recipes can require a timber, stone, metal, textile or crystal source. A source grants access and then produces the shared stock; required access must remain available when starting a recipe. This keeps four resource bars while making a metal-poor forest different from a mining realm. K represents prepared teaching and ritual work, not knowledge erased from memory when spent. All resource gains and costs are shown before commitment.

Six production channels: buildings expand capacity; training recruits ordinary units; kennels/nurseries/forges produce beasts or constructs; research unlocks magic; workshops craft equipment; a dedicated hero building creates the sole hero. Every playable recipe must define inputs, source access, facility, workers, duration, upkeep and population or binding cost. This report specifies the hero recipes and ordinary production identities; detailed unit/building prices remain a tuning task.

One job per facility queue. Pay the recipe upfront. An upgrade improves that queue or unlocks a recipe; extra buildings add ordinary production capacity within the faction's limits. Terrain and staff remain necessary. Destroying a production building loses unfinished work; voluntary cancellation returns half its stock cost. Completed units and items have individual identities, preventing cancellation or capture from duplicating outputs.

Ordinary units need supply; summons need binding capacity. Infantry use 1 supply, elite companies 2 and large creatures 3 as initial tuning values. Workers use housing capacity instead. Each summoned group also occupies a binding slot; starting capacity is 2, expanded only by specified structures. A summoned entity cannot be sacrificed for more resources than it cost.

Magic has three forms: research permanently unlocks hero techniques; workshops prepare consumable spell charges; major rituals consume resources and time at use. An ability states which form applies, so a researched technique is not accidentally charged as both a scroll and a ritual. Hero combat techniques also use personal readiness, normally 6, with recovery restoring 3. Worldbreaker Melkor has 12 and recovers 6; section 05a defines this exception.

No economy needs another faction to exist. Basic exchange converts surplus P/M into K at a poor rate; a core ritual converts 20M + 10K into 10E over two turns. These slow fallback routes prevent loss of a rare node from permanently blocking hero recreation. Hero base recipes require generic stocks; source access applies to the component step. If that access is lost, the core can synthesize the faction component for **30M + 20K + 10E over three turns**, with no source prerequisite. It grants no production knowledge or source access for other recipes. Strong local sources and trade remain far more efficient.

02 / Create, lose and recreate the one hero

The rule is one fixed hero type per faction and at most one living instance. Melkor selects one of two doctrines at setup; both use the same identity and hero slot, and recreation preserves the choice. Before first creation, during production and after death there can be zero. Recruitment, capture, promotion, summoning and annexation never grant a second controllable hero. Ordinary captains and specialist units have limited abilities but no hero progression tree.

- Establish the hero building.** A sanctuary, hall, forge or lair contains the faction's single hero queue. Additional copies do not unlock additional hero queues.
- Collect the recipe and signature component.** Resources come from production, trade or exploration. Each faction makes its own component at its hero building for an additional 10M + 5K over one turn; its material or terrain access differs by faction.
- Create the hero.** Consume the component and pay the recipe below upfront. Production locks the slot, preventing simultaneous jobs. The hero appears only when training or manifestation completes.
- Develop the hero.** Three branching specializations develop the same role. Appearance and personality can vary at campaign setup; the underlying faction hero type stays fixed.
- Recreate after death.** Pay the full recipe, a new component and the full production time again. The same identity, level and chosen perks return. There is no free timer-based revival and no additional hero slot.

Hero recipe code	Resource cost, excluding component	Production time
D - Divine: all Valar and Melkor	120M + 100K + 120E	4 turns
A - Maia/Istar, including Sauron	80M + 80K + 70E	3 turns
E - Elven clan hero	60P + 80M + 50K + 25E	3 turns
C - Dwarf, Orc, Troll or Hobbit hero	60P + 60M + 30K + 10E	2 turns
B - Ent, Eagle, Wolf or Spider hero	90P + 40M + 30K + 40E	3 turns

Human kingdoms use their own recipes in section 08. These numbers are prototype hypotheses; tune starting stocks, income and map rewards for an attainable first hero rather than copying identical opening economies. Creature recipes represent playable recruitment, magical growth or reconstruction, not literal real-world maturation.

Death has lasting cost: travel time is lost, commitments fail, and carried equipment drops once at the death site. Recreating the hero does not copy those items. Recover them or craft replacements. Bound starter gear cannot be traded, salvaged or duplicated for profit. Capture of a corpse or equipment never blocks the basic return recipe. The faction keeps operating through its ordinary units.

A destroyed hero building can be rebuilt by a surviving worker. Losing all recovery footholds can end the faction, according to the scenario; losing the hero alone does not. A living captive still occupies the slot and needs rescue or an explicitly chosen surrender that ends the current incarnation, drops equipment once, and opens the ordinary paid recreation process.

03 / Gods, cities and mixed factions

God factions win through the hero's presence and domain. The fourteen Valar and Worldbreaker Melkor receive a small sanctuary economy: one core plus four support plots, no new independent cities, two ordinary production jobs running at once and a starting supply ceiling of 12. Their exceptional hero uses no supply slot but still needs readiness and travel time. One utility plot can provide housing, stores or exchange; the other plots force meaningful production choices.

Aulë can create outstanding tools and defensive works, but his few queues cannot manufacture a whole industrial empire. Yavanna excels at habitat; she does not receive every civilian building. Dark Architect Melkor instead develops fortress cities and mass creature production under section 05a's limits; he shares essence with his monsters and degrades exploited sites. Sauron is deliberately an industrial Maia faction: his hero is below the strongest Valar in raw power, while his city development is much stronger.

Proposed starting supply ceilings: Valar and Worldbreaker Melkor 12; Dark Architect Melkor 36, expandable to 60; other Maiar and Istari 18; Elves and Dwarves 24; human kingdoms and Orcs 36; creature factions 18. Ordinary settlements can grow capacity through infrastructure and upkeep. The Valar and Worldbreaker remain at 12. New production stops above a cap; existing units never lose loyalty. Balrogs and Dragons cannot be transferred. These limits balance supporting armies, not intrinsic hero strength.

Cooperation	What can transfer	What stays with its faction
Trade	Materials, provisions, ordinary items, trained mounts, spell charges	Unresearched recipes and unique hero identity
Auxiliary contract	Eligible ordinary companies or constructs; never Balrogs or Dragons	Hero slot and faction-wide passive bonuses
Joint project	Labor, materials and a named service	Ownership, maintenance duties and cancellation terms remain explicit
Coalition	Coordinated missions by independent factions	Each faction keeps its own hero, budget and objective

A coalition can therefore contain several heroes, because several independent factions participate. One player-controlled faction still has only one. An allied hero follows agreed missions rather than joining the player's hero inventory. Annexing a settlement never transfers its hero queue; the former hero departs or the independent faction remains a vassal with its own agency. Valar and Worldbreaker annexation yields tribute or an allied enclave. Dark Architect may annex within his three-city limit. Balrog and Dragon ownership and command never transfer through any coalition, auxiliary or annexation rule.

Counterplay: threaten supplies, expose plans, contest essence, force the hero to travel or split objectives. Avoid equalizing a god and a mortal through identical damage statistics. Terrain and scenario objectives must give weaker factions alternatives to a direct duel.

Turn structure: three strategic operations plus one personal hero commitment each week. Established production queues run separately, bounded by facilities, workforce and resources. This replaces revision 2's rule that every ongoing build occupies an operation slot. A hero can empower one workshop, lead a battle, travel or recover; routine production continues during death and recreation.

04 / Valar: sky, sea, craft and boundaries

Every row is a separate faction with the named Power as its only hero; recipe D. The two building families fit inside the sanctuary cap. Troops, animals, constructs and manifestations are ordinary units, never extra heroes. The first listed building creates the hero.

Sole hero	Buildings	Ordinary unit / creature	Magic / item
Manwë	Windwatch; Herald Court	Spear herald / courier-eagle	Gale corridor / sapphire command sceptre
Varda	Star Observatory; Beacon Terrace	Lantern guard / lumen construct	Reveal the hidden / star-glass lens
Ulmo	Spring Sanctuary; Tide Gate	Ford keeper / current-spirit	Raise or divide waters / shell horn
Aulë	Master Forge; Stone Workshop	Smith-guard / articulated stone porter	Shape the earthworks / maker's hammer
Yavanna	Seed Vault; Living Grove	Grove tender / root guardian	Awaken the canopy / grafting staff
Námo / Mandos	Hall of Waiting; Judgment Gate	Threshold sentinel / oath-echo	Bind a passage / judgment seal
Irmo / Lórien	Dream Garden; Vision Pavilion	Dream attendant / phantom hound	Sleep and misdirection / dream lantern

Components: Manwë uses a wind-carved crystal; Varda a star lens; Ulmo a shell focus; Aulë a forged core; Yavanna a living seed; Námo a stone seal; Irmo a dreamglass. Each uses its fitting M-source tag, or in Yavanna's case a living grove. Spell and item names are proposed recipes; generic focuses do not duplicate canonical unique artifacts.

05 / Valar: life, memory and force

Every row is a separate faction with the named Power as its only hero; recipe D. The two building families fit inside the sanctuary cap. Troops, animals, constructs and manifestations are ordinary units, never extra heroes. The first listed building creates the hero.

Sole hero	Buildings	Ordinary unit / creature	Magic / item
Nienna	House of Mourning; Refuge Cloister	Mercy attendant / memory lantern	Unbroken resolve / grey mantle
Oromë	Hunt Lodge; Trail Kennel	Mounted tracker / hunting-hound pack	Reveal the quarry / hunting horn
Tulkas	Wrestling Yard; Muster Ground	Wrestler / pack aurochs	Break the siege / grip wraps
Nessa	Dance Court; Relay Stable	Runner / courier stag	Fleet company / step-light anklets
Vána	Bloom Nursery; Song Aviary	Garden tender / songbird swarm	Sudden flowering / renewal wreath
Estë	Rest House; Healing Pool	Field healer / rescue hind	Deep restoration / healing veil
Vairë	Chronicle Loom; Archive Hall	Recorder-guard / threadward effigy	Reconstruct the past / memory shuttle

Components: Nienna uses a mourning veil; Oromë a carved horn; Tulkas forged grip bands; Nessa a woven relay cord; Vána a flowering circlet; Estë a healing vessel; Vairë a woven memory. All are made through the common component recipe. A healer, courier or living grove can be decisive even when its faction produces little siege equipment.

05a / Melkor: two doctrines, one hero

Choose at campaign setup. Both doctrines represent the same Melkor, use one hero slot and preserve the chosen doctrine after death. They cannot coexist, combine their bonuses or switch through recreation. Both use recipe D and the black iron component: normally **130M + 105K + 120E over five sequential turns**, including component manufacture but excluding the core's construction. The established component-synthesis fallback remains available.

System	Worldbreaker - hero oriented	Dark Architect - city oriented
Power focus	Overwhelming personal combat, destructive magic and direct intervention	A formidable commander investing power in fortresses, industry and creatures
Readiness	12 maximum; recovery restores 6	6 maximum; recovery restores 3
Cities	One Dark Sanctuary core plus four support plots; no additional cities	One Black Citadel with eight support plots; up to two additional Fortress Holds with six plots each
Ordinary production	Two concurrent jobs across the faction	Six concurrent jobs across the faction
Army supply	12, fixed	36; each completed, held Fortress Hold adds 12, up to 60
Great-creature capacity	2 points, fixed	4 points; each held Fortress Hold adds 2, up to 8
Monster production	Costly, slow elite companions; no Winged Dragon breeding	Dedicated breeding and manifestation industry; Winged Dragons unlocked through research
Principal weakness	Limited territory coverage and replacement capacity	Expensive supply networks, vulnerable worksites and weaker personal intervention

Worldbreaker's hero kit

Worldbreak [4 readiness] breaks a defended obstacle or damages a tightly held position. **Black Storm [4]** creates a dangerous local area that can also obstruct allies. **Dread Step [2]** crosses a short tactical gap; it never skips strategic travel. These proposed techniques emphasize Melkor acting personally. Large effects have visible preparation and bounded areas.

Dark Architect's hero kit

Forge Will [3 readiness + 10E] advances one staffed production job by one turn, once per strategic turn, with no same-turn start-and-finish. **Iron Edict [3]** uses the hero commitment to coordinate up to three owned great creatures on one connected front. **Citadel Shroud [3]** temporarily protects one prepared worksite. He retains ordinary combat and terror but does not gain Worldbreaker's kit.

Better control means greater capacity and coordination. Both doctrines have identical, unconditional loyalty from every Balrog and Dragon. Command buildings relay Melkor's orders; workers, captains and allies never gain independent authority over those creatures. Melkor's nonhero units remain nonheroes even when individually powerful.

05b / Melkor's exclusive creature industry

Only Melkor can own, produce or issue orders to Balrogs and Dragons. This covers every age and form: eggs, hatchlings, drakes, ground and winged Dragons, Balrogs, and revived or transformed variants. No faction, including Sauron, can buy, tame, charm, dominate, hire or inherit them. Allied players cannot issue their orders. Captivity can restrain them, never convert them. Spell interference may damage, stun or block them but cannot make them follow another will.

Product	Facility	Base cost / turns	Supply / great-creature points
Siege brute	War Pens	40P + 50M + 10K + 5E / 3	3 / 0
Lesser Drake	Dragon Brood Vault	40P + 35M + 10K + 20E / 3	3 / 1
Ground Dragon	Dragon Brood Vault, tier 2	120P + 100M + 40K + 80E / 6	6 / 1
Winged Dragon	Sky Brood Vault, tier 3; Dark Architect only	160P + 140M + 60K + 120E / 8	8 / 2
Balrog	Black Crucible, tier 2	100M + 60K + 100E / 6	6 / 1

The War Furnace supplies metalwork; Dragon vaults breed; the Crucible manifests Balrogs through an invented production ritual. Each creature is one individually counted unit, not an unlimited group hidden inside one slot. These creatures use the listed supply and great-creature points instead of ordinary summon binding slots. Siege brutes remain available to other permitted factions; exclusivity applies to the Dragon and Balrog families.

Industry advantage: Dark Architect can research Brood Discipline at a Command Spire for 60M + 40K + 30E over three turns. It reduces future Dragon/Balrog base production time by 25%, rounded up: 3/6/8 becomes 3/5/6 turns. Prices stay unchanged. Each facility still runs one job, within the faction's six-job ceiling. Queued creatures reserve supply and great-creature points, preventing mass completion beyond capacity.

Permanent allegiance: Melkor's bodily death does not break the bond. His player continues issuing his orders through the faction interface while rebuilding the hero; bodily abilities remain unavailable. Capture, low supplies, destroyed command buildings and low morale never cause desertion, rebellion or obedience to another ruler. Shortages stall production or weaken combat readiness. Losing a Hold blocks new capacity-consuming jobs until there is room; existing and already-reserved creatures remain his.

No transfer loopholes: occupied facilities halt these queues; stolen eggs cannot hatch under foreign control; copied recipes, rings and resurrection spells cannot change their owner. They are removed from the independent playable faction list. Without an active Melkor faction, they may appear only as Melkor-aligned, unrecruitable remnants following his last orders. After elimination, survivors likewise defend their last assigned territory. Another ruler never becomes their master.

06 / Sauron and five generic Istari orders

Each order has one generated hero of the listed type, using recipe A. The first building creates its hero and signature component. The component's required source gives the order a distinct opening. Other trained casters and constructs remain ordinary support units. These are original orders, not five canonical Wizard identities.

Faction / sole hero	Buildings / component access	Ordinary production	Magic / item
Ember / Kindler	Hearth Sanctuary; Refuge Lodge / metal, ember focus	Hearth Wardens; Ashlight spirits	Rally through terror; shelter ward / Oath Lantern
Grove / Grovekeeper	Seedwell; Medicine Nursery / living grove, growth focus	Thornkeepers; Moth Clouds	Root snare; recovery bloom / Renewal Charm
Veil / Veilweaver	Hidden Observatory; Safehouse / glass, mist focus	Quiet Envoys; Mist Doubles	False signal; concealed passage / False-Signal Seal
Forge / Artificer	Arcane Foundry; Service Depot / metal, binding focus	Wrought Sentinels; Bound Sparks	Repair supplied equipment; reinforce cover / Repair Matrix
Star / Wayseer	Astral Hall; Beacon Station / crystal, star focus	Beacon Riders; Star Motes	Route warning; prepared interception / Wayglass

Distinct costs: Ember needs supplies for occupied refuges; Grove needs viable habitat; Veil needs staffed contacts and fragile decoys; Forge consumes material even when using magic to repair; Star needs connected beacons and verified observations. Summoned spirits and motes occupy binding capacity, while trained followers need ordinary supply.

Sauron: the industrial controller

Sole hero: Sauron, recipe A, created at a Binding Forge with a forged binding core. **Buildings:** Binding Forge, Command Tower, foundries and tribute depots. **Production:** armored overseers, werewolves, siege equipment and lesser binding rings. **Hero capabilities:** borrowed disguise, terror and coordinated command. **Perk:** functioning client networks improve mobilization. **Weakness:** surveillance, armies and industry compete for resources; exposed dependency creates secession opportunities. Sauron's command, bindings and rings never control, create or revive Balrogs or Dragons; those families belong exclusively to Melkor.

A lesser binding ring is an ordinary invented item. The One Ring remains a unique optional world project with one identity and disclosed consequences. The standard production mode's repeatable hero return does not use permanent Ring-destruction elimination. A separate historical scenario can make destroying the One decisive, with that exception shown before play. This prevents the standard hero rule from silently changing mid-match.

Optional character flavor: generated names, portraits, voices and histories make each Kindler or Wayseer memorable. Their mechanical identity comes from the order. A named Wizard can appear as a narrative reference in an authored scenario without creating a second controllable hero.

07 / Elves by clan and house

Each row has one fixed hero type; recipe E. The listed hero hall is also the component workshop. Noldorin houses and Telerin branches are different levels of ancestry; the selection screen presents the family tree rather than calling them eight equal ancestral kindreds. Each faction can recruit basic workers, defenders and archers alongside its specialties.

Clan or house / sole hero	Hero hall / component	Signature production	Magic and equipment identity
Vanyar / Concord Singer	Chorus Court / tuned songstone	Banner Fellowships; ceremonial standards	Formation hymns, courage wards and resonant instruments
House of Fëanor / Jewelwright	Gem Atelier / cut crystal	Masterwork blades; bound-light jewels	Stored radiance, crafted traps and powerful personal equipment
House of Fingolfin / Shield Marshal	Pass-watch Fortress / forged shield seal	Mounted Wardens; reinforced gates	Protective banners, disciplined counterattacks and durable armor
House of Finarfin / Lore Envoy	Hall of Welcome / inscribed pact	Healing singers; guest workshops	Restorative songs, translation charms and diplomacy tools
Falmari / Tide Captain	Harbor Hall / carved shell compass	Swan-ships; Harbor Beacons	Calm-passage charms, sea cloaks and maritime signals
Sindar / March Warden	Hidden Court / woven veil	Hidden Watch-houses; woodland companies	Concealment mantles, boundary wards and song-lures
Nandor / Woodland Pathfinder	Forest Waystation / living trailmark	Canopy Scouts; trained woodland mounts	Root snares, hidden paths and practical bows
Avari clan / Frontier Mediator	Clan Lodge / local waystone	Portable Workshops; decentralized Waymarks	Mobile camp wards, local lore and adaptable travel gear

Tradeoff: an Elven clan maintains fewer, more costly specialists than a human kingdom or Orc fortress. Long training and skilled workshops make preserving units valuable. Item production can be exceptional without making every ordinary recruit a spellcaster.

The hero's three branches express its existing role. A Jewelwright chooses weapons, protective works or utility craft; a March Warden chooses concealment, defense or border diplomacy. A clan cannot buy another clan's hero through an alliance.

Nandorin and Avari factions can recruit animals through their specialist grounds. Elven armies chiefly train people and craft enchanted objects; they do not all need an invented monster-breeding roster. A Fëanorian player can obtain an eligible allied beast or construct without learning its recipe; Balrogs and all Dragon forms are excluded. Melian's Girdle remains her faction's major enchantment, not a free racial ability for every Sindarin player.

08 / Exactly three human kingdoms

Each kingdom has one unique hero type, recreated through its own recipe. Every kingdom can build housing, farms, stores, roads, barracks and basic defenses. Their specialist production gives each a different reason to expand and trade. The hero building makes a signature component using the common 10M + 5K, one-turn rule.

Kingdom	Sole hero, creation and component	Distinct production
Gondor	Citadel Engineer ; Citadel Hall; stone command seal. 60P + 80M + 30K + 10E / 2 turns	Fortified Supply Depots, Shield Companies, siege engines, repair kits and defensive standards
Rohan	Rider Marshal ; Muster Hall; forged horse crest. 100P + 40M + 20K + 10E / 2 turns	Horse-breeding Steads, Rider Companies, mounted scouts, remounts, saddles and rally horns
Númenor	Ocean Warden ; Admiralty Hall; carved sea compass. 70P + 70M + 60K + 20E / 3 turns	Deep-water Shipyards, Expedition Ships, marines, navigation tools, signal towers and sea wards

Gondor: hold and engineer

Hero actions: Field Repair restores a supplied defensive position; Ordered Withdrawal preserves an endangered company. **Perk:** prepared depots extend operational endurance. **Branches:** fortification, siege engineering or supply command. **Production weakness:** armies and walls consume metal and maintenance. **Counter:** bypass its strong points, contest roads and force dispersed defense.

Rohan: concentrate and move

Hero actions: Muster Riders draws nearby companies together; Relief Charge interrupts a threatened approach. **Perk:** mounted forces reposition rapidly on suitable ground. **Branches:** scouting, shock action or relief logistics. **Production weakness:** horses require pasture, fodder and training; a stable does not create instant mature mounts without stock. **Counter:** defended chokepoints, broken terrain and attacks on fodder.

Númenor: reach and sustain

Hero actions: Convoy Command organizes distant supply; Coastal Landing coordinates an embarked force. **Perk:** fleets can maintain more demanding routes. **Branches:** navigation, expedition command or maritime diplomacy. **Production weakness:** ships consume several material sources and are vulnerable away from harbors. **Counter:** blockade, damaged ports and commitments deep inland.

Human magic focuses on learned support, prepared wards and crafted equipment. They can obtain enchantments through trade or a slow local workshop. Strong production and adaptable armies compensate for heroes who cannot confront the greatest gods directly.

Númenor, Gondor and Rohan are the only selectable human kingdoms in this revision. Other human communities may appear as neutral settlements or narrative actors. The shared roster is explicitly cross-age; adding another playable human kingdom later requires a new design decision.

09 / Dwarves, Orcs and Hobbit communities

Each row has one hero, recipe C. Ordinary workers, storage, food access and defenses support the specialist economy. The first building creates the hero; the component uses the common recipe and the matching source. These Dwarven choices are realm traditions, not three exhaustive ancestral houses.

Faction / sole hero	Buildings / component	Production and magic	Strategic constraint
Khazad-dûm / Deep Surveyor	Deepworks Hall; Tunnel Foundry / survey core	Tunnel Guards, mining engines, stone porters, survey lenses and passage wards	Food imports, ventilation and exposed entrances
Belegost / Armor Master	Mail Hall; Mask Workshop / tempered armor seal	Masked Vanguard, protected haulers, hazard armor and resistance fittings	Slow metal-intensive output; protection must match the threat
Nogrod / Master Artificer	Precision Forge; Commission House / master-tool core	Engineers, breach tools, small mechanisms, crafted weapons and durable inscriptions	Specialist labor and rare inputs constrain throughput
Orc fortress-clan / Warband Organizer	Warband Hall; Salvage Foundry; Tunnel Pens / black iron badge	Tunnel Raiders, wolf riders, siege brutes, crude artillery and scavenged arms	High food demand; coercive organization increases instability
Hobbit Shire / Shirekeeper	Common Hall; Commons Farm; Watch House / hearth token	Fieldhands, Bounders, pack ponies, superior food stores, travel kits and Hearthward Lanterns	Vulnerable to occupation and prolonged open battle

Dwarven heroes: Deep Surveyor opens routes and identifies resources; Armor Master adapts a company's protection; Master Artificer specializes tools and siege support. Their equipment can strengthen other factions, but each buyer must maintain it and find a suitable bearer.

Orc hero: Warband Organizer unlocks three approaches: disciplined mustering, aggressive raiding or industrial salvage. It can bargain with clans, rally a broken formation and accelerate an existing salvage job. The player chooses institutions; Orc identity does not mandate a single political allegiance. Wolf riders require trained mounts, and siege brutes require dedicated pens, supplies and longer production.

Hobbit hero: Shirekeeper coordinates hidden movement, emergency provisioning and community defense. Its branches emphasize stealth, mutual aid or trade. Food and dependable support can make a small community strategically important without giving it a disguised god-level combatant.

These peoples have magic access through craft, qualified specialists, bought enchantments or explicitly invented research. Standard recruits do not receive every spell. Construct and creature production supplements the social identity of each faction rather than replacing it.

Upgrades: level 1 produces basic units; level 2 adds one specialized branch; level 3 unlocks its elite output. Choose between competing branches within a structure. Extra structures require workers, space and maintenance, and never create another hero slot.

10 / Creatures and guardians

A **lair, eyrie or grove is this faction's settlement.** It provides appropriate production and storage rather than copying a human city. All produced creatures are ordinary units. The hero's exceptional status, progression and return queue are unique even when followers share its species.

Faction / sole hero / recipe	Hero building / component	Ordinary production and buildings	Magic / crafted asset
Ent Grove / Grove Elder / B	Moot Grove / living heartwood	Living Nursery grows Sapling Guardians; Rootworks grows shelters and defensive roots	Rootward protection / Rootward Totem
Eagle Eyrie / Skywarden / B	High Nest / feather sky-knot	Training Ledge recruits Scout Flights; Harness Perch prepares Rescue Flights	Wind guidance / carried Wind Knot
Troll Hold / Stonebreaker / C	Chieftain's Hall / iron-stone badge	Drill Yard trains Shield Trolls; Breach Workshop equips Siege Crews	Purchased protection / Stonehide Plate
Wolf Pack / Packwarden / B	Gathering Den / scent token	Scent Den raises Trackers; Pack Ground organizes Runners and hunting groups	Moon-marked pursuit / Moonfang Token
Spider Brood / Brood Matriarch / B	Royal Hollow / venom-silk spindle	Silk Nursery creates Weblayers; Brood Chamber raises Venom Stalkers	Concealed webs / Nightweb Snare

Every component uses the common component cost; source requirements follow its material or habitat. Biological production uses existing populations, recruitment or disclosed magical growth to fit the campaign timescale. Dragon and Balrog production belongs exclusively to Melkor under section 05b. They are powerful ordinary units, not separate factions or extra heroes.

Hero roles: Grove Elder anchors territorial defense; Skywarden intercepts and extracts; Stonebreaker breaches; Packwarden coordinates pursuit; Brood Matriarch prepares ambush terrain. Each has three specialization branches within that role.

Counters: burn or divide a grove, threaten an eyrie, deny Troll supplies, deplete hunting territory or clear web routes. Give opponents warning, approach choices and ways to contest the objective rather than requiring every faction to win a frontal fight.

A lair asset strengthens a territory or is carried appropriately; creatures do not equip humanoid swords and boots by default. Lair upgrades, protective harnesses, caches, traps and ritual sites occupy the same design space as equipment and buildings elsewhere.

11 / Other Maiar remain distinct factions

These optional factions retain the broader roster from revision 2. Each has its named being as its sole hero, recipe A, with a component produced at the first listed building. Their cities remain modest: one enclave with six support plots and supply 18. They emphasize a narrow service or domain. Production below is invented gameplay, especially where the source describes an individual only briefly.

Sole hero	Buildings / component	Ordinary production	Hero magic / item
Melian	Sanctuary Court; Veil Garden / woven sanctuary seal	Border attendants, refuge keepers and veil wisps	Bounded Girdle, concealment / sanctuary mantle
Ossë	Storm Haven; Surf Works / storm-shell core	Shore guards, storm skiffs and surf constructs	Hazardous seas, landing disruption / tidebreaker charm
Uinen	Haven Pool; Rescue Yard / pearl current-knot	Rescue crews, protected fishing craft and current guides	Calm water, convoy protection / safe-passage token
Arien	Solar Court; Dawn Terrace / fire crystal	Dawn sentries, light mirrors and sun-motes	Expose movement, contest shadow / daylight lens
Tilion	Lunar Lodge; Nightwatch Platform / silver moon-mark	Night scouts, patrol riders and moon-motes	Interception, night-route warning / silver sight
Eönwë	Herald Hall; Expedition Camp / heraldic seal	Supplied herald companies, banner guards and siege crews	Coordinated advance, rally / commission banner
Ilmarë	Signal Court; Star Relay / signal crystal	Couriers, beacon keepers and signal motes	Warning relays, illumination / witness glass

Different from the Valar: these factions have somewhat more institutional capacity and lower hero costs, while their heroes have narrower reach and lower raw power than the greatest Powers. Melian invests in a stationary sanctuary; Eönwë concentrates supplied military strength; Ilmarë turns communication into strategic advantage.

Persistent magic: a maintained ward, major veil or protected route occupies an Anchor with a defined area and dependency. A hero has at most three Anchors; Melian's major Girdle uses two. Ordinary buildings use plots, not Anchors. Release ends the sustained magic, frees capacity at turn end and refunds no resources. Hero death suspends hero-dependent Anchors until return; ordinary physical buildings continue functioning.

Arien and Tilion use a small local manifestation for direct play and announced celestial routes for regional effects. Their hero deaths and returns are explicit sandbox inventions. They do not physically replace the world's Sun or Moon with a freshly purchased item, nor bombard the whole map without warning.

Unique identity: the game never creates a second Manwë, Sauron or Melian because another production queue completed. In multiplayer, if later implemented, named factions would require exclusive selection; custom races/orders would still obey one hero per player faction.

12 / A practical example and development order

A three-faction coalition: Rohan supplies cavalry and food; a Fëanorian clan supplies enchanted equipment; an Ember order prepares courage wards and support spirits. Each faction retains its own single hero. A joint army can contain ordinary units from all three, but recruiting their companies does not transfer their heroes or research trees. Melkor's Balrogs and Dragons can fight alongside allies only under Melkor's own orders; joint command never includes them.

Rohan's opening: build a Horse-breeding Stead, secure fodder and train workers. At the Muster Hall, spend 10M + 5K and one turn to make a horse crest. Then spend 100P + 40M + 20K + 10E and two turns to create the Rider Marshal. The full first-hero chain therefore costs **100P + 50M + 25K + 10E over three sequential production turns**, excluding the Hall's construction. Gathering and other queues can operate concurrently.

If the Marshal dies, Rohan keeps its farms, army and production. Recover the fallen hero's equipment or replace it. Recreate the horse crest and pay the same complete chain again. The Marshal returns with the same development, while the lost time and expenditure create a real opening for opponents. Another kingdom's hero cannot fill the empty slot.

First prototype: Gondor, Rohan, one Elven house, one generic Istar order, one Orc clan and one Vala. Test whether economic factions can exploit the god's limited coverage, whether crafted heroes feel worth saving, and whether returning after death preserves tension. Test Númenor on a coastal map. Then test each Melkor doctrine separately against the same opposition, including a hero death and an occupied breeding site.

Required checks: one living/pending hero per faction; exactly three human kingdom entries; one fixed hero type for every entry; no inventory duplication after death; no annexation bypass of hero or divine city limits; viable recreation after losing a contested resource site; useful production without the hero present; Melkor doctrine persistence, exclusive Dragon/Balrog command under every capture/trade/magic/death path, reserved creature capacity, and readability at the distant camera.

This specification contains **49 factions and 50 starting profiles:** fourteen Valar, Melkor with two mutually exclusive doctrines, Sauron, five Istari orders, eight Elven profiles, three human kingdoms, three Dwarven traditions, Orcs, six creature/community factions and seven other Maiar. Dragons and Balrogs are Melkor-exclusive units. The roster follows the single-hero rule; two profiles never create two Melkors.

Evidence and revision boundary: the supplied 461-page Silmarillion was read for the earlier source report. Its domains, peoples and conflicts inform these faction identities. Production recipes, generic orders, constructs, city caps and repeatable resurrection deliberately adapt that material for play. Revision 2's permanent-death restrictions, named-Wizard menu, broad human roster and ongoing-build order cost are superseded. Revision 4 additionally supersedes Melkor's uniform city limit and the independent Dragon/Balrog factions. His two doctrines, exclusive creature allegiance and post-death command are explicit gameplay choices. Earlier reports and PDFs are preserved under output/archive/.

The full reading notes remain beside this document. No game implementation or balance simulation has been completed. The next milestone is a small playable economic and hero loop, with the same huge-map, tiny-character visual direction.